What's the Worst That Could Happen?

By Bruce Coville

Good luck and I have rarely shared the same park bench. Sometimes I think Murphy's law – "If something can go wrong, it **will**" – was invented just for me. I suppose the fact that my name is Murphy Murphy might have something to do with that feeling. Yeah: Murphy Murphy. It's like a family curse. *(Beat)* The last name I got from my father, of course. The first name came down from my mother's side, where it is a tradition for the firstborn son. You would think my mother might have considered that before she married Dad, but love makes fools of us all. I guess. *(Beat)* Anyway, you can see that right from the beginning of my life, if something could go wrong, it did. Okay, I suppose it could have been worse. I could have been born with two heads or something. On the other hand, as I lie here in my hospital bed trying to work out exactly how I got here, there are times when I wonder if being born with two

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heads might not have been the best thing. *(Beat)* To begin with, I want to say here and now that Mikey Farnsworth should take at least part of the blame for this situation. The one I am not going to blame is Tiffany Grimsley, though if I hadn't had this stupid crush on her, it never would have happened.

INTRODUCTION

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MIKEY: Man, you've got it bad for Tiffany!

MURPHY: *(Blushing and embarrassed)* What are you talking about?

MIKEY: *(laughing)* Look at you blush, Murphy! There's no point in trying to hide it. I watched you drooling over her in social studies class today. And you've only mentioned her, like, sixteen times since we got home this afternoon.

I do not think I have actually drooled over Tiffany during social studies class. But it is hard not to

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think about her then, because she sits right in front of me. It's the last class of the day, and the October sunlight comes in and catches in her golden hair in a way that makes it hard to breathe. *(To Mikey, groaning)* What am I going to do?

MIKEY: *(shrugs)* Either you suffer in silence, or you tell her you like her.

Is he nuts? If you tell a girl you like her, it puts you totally out in the open. I mean, you've got no place to hide. And there are really only two possible responses you're going to get from her: (a) She likes you, too *(expression of pure terror)* or (b) anything else, which is, like, totally, utterly humiliating. Then, on Wednesday, it's as if the gods are smiling on me, which not something I am used to. Tiffany grabs my arm on the way out of social studies and says

TIFFANY: Can I talk to you for a second, Murphy?

MURPHY: Sure.

Not very eloquent, but it is better than the first thought that crossed my mind, which is, "Anytime, anywhere, any moment of the day." It is also better

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than, "Your words would be like nectar flowering into the hungry mouths of my ears," which was a line I had come up with for a poem I was writing about her. She hands me a folded-over set of papers, and my heart skips a beat. Can this be a love letter?

TIFFANY: I wrote this skit for drama club, and I thought maybe you would do it with me next Friday. I think you'd be just right for the part.

MURPHY: Yes!

She gives me one of those sunrise smiles of hers, grabs my arm and gives it a squeeze, and says,

TIFFANY: Thanks. This is going to be fun.

Then she's gone, leaving me with a memory of her fingers on my arm and a wish that I had started pumping iron when I was in first grade, so my biceps would have been ready for this moment.

MIKEY: Murphy, you can't go onstage with her. You can't even move when you get onstage. Don't you remember what happened in fifth grade?

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As if I could forget . . . . *(Flashback)* Mrs. Carmichael had cast me as George Washington in our class play, and I was, I want to tell you, pretty good during rehearsals. But when they opened the curtain and I saw the audience…well, let's just say that when my mother saw the look on my face, she actually let out a scream. She told me later she thought I was having a heart attack. As for me, my mouth went drier than day-old toast, and the only reason I didn't bolt from the stage was that I couldn't move my arms or legs. Heck, I couldn't even move my fingers. I couldn't even squeak! They had to cancel the performance. Even after the curtains were closed, it took two teachers and a janitor to carry me back to the classroom. *(To Mikey)* Oh, man, what am I gonna do? I wail.

MIKEY: Come on, let's look at the script. Maybe all you have to do is sit there and she'll do all the acting. *(the boys leaf through the script)*

No such luck. The script, which is called "Debbie and the Doofus," is very funny. It also calls for me to say a lot of lines. It also calls for me to act like a

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complete dork. Immediately, I begin to wonder why Tiffany thinks I would be just right for this role. After two days I know not only my lines, but all of Tiffany's lines, too, as well as the lines for Laurel Gibbon, who is going to be playing the waitress at the little restaurant where we go for our date. My theory is that I will enjoy rehearsals and the excuse they give me to be with Tiffany, and then pray for a meteor to strike me before the day of the performance.

MIKEY: *(Scanning the skies)* No meteor yet! Maybe you could be sick that day.

MURPHY: *(Shaking his head)* If I let her down, I will hate myself forever.

MIKEY: *(Rolling his eyes)* Maybe you should run away from home.

Despite my prayers, Friday arrives. I don't suppose I really expected God to cancel it, though I would have been deeply appreciative if he had. I go through the day in a state of cold terror. At 2:45 Mrs. Whitcomb, the drama club coach, comes back to wish us luck.

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MRS. WHITCOMB: Okay, kids – break a leg!

This is how people wish each other luck in theater?!

TIFFANY: Are you excited?

MURPHY: You have no idea.

Inside me, a small voice is screaming,

VOICE: What were you thinking of you moron? You are going to humiliate yourself in front of all these people, including the girl you would cut out your heart for, who will be even more humiliated than you are because it's her skit that you are messing up! Run away! Run away!

My stomach clenches. Cold sweat starts out on my brow.

TIFFANY: Murphy! Your shoelace!

(glancing down) I have forgotten to untie it, which is the key to one of my first funny bits. I lift my foot to take care of the lace. At that instant the curtain opens, which startles me so much that I lose my balance and fall over, landing onstage in full view of the audience. There they are. The enemy. The people who are going to stare at me, judge me, whisper about me tomorrow. I am so frozen with terror I cannot move.

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This is it, I will never be able to face another living human being.

TIFFANY: *(whispering)* Murphy, are you all right?

(is startled out of his frozen terror and speaks to the audience) For the sound of that voice, I would do anything! *(He turns to the invisible door of the script and fake knocks)* Knock-knock. Knockity-knock-knock. To my surprise, the audience finds this funny. Tiffany comes to the door, and we go through our opening business. But something is happening. I'm not making up lines, but I am making bigger gestures, *(gestures broadly)* broader moves, weirder voices than I did in rehearsal. People are howling. I am a genius! Who is this funny person, making everyone laugh? *(with a flourish he shakes out the cloth napkin . . . and blows his nose in it – He inspects the results and is fascinated by the imaginary boogers)* The audience is just about screaming. This kind of laughter is even better than the sound of Tiffany's voice. Laurel comes back with our "order" which, because this is a skit and we are on a low budget, is a plate of Hostess cupcakes. Chocolate. I am supposed to eat in a disgusting way.

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(picks up a cupcake and stuffs it whole into his mouth.) I deliver my next line – which is about how beautiful she is – with bits of chocolate spewing out. It's disgusting but hilarious. Desperate to keep the riff going, I cram another entire cupcake in my mouth. This is when disaster strikes. Suddenly, I discover that I can't breathe because there is a chocolate logjam in my throat. I try to give my next line, but nothing comes out.

Which is when Mikey comes barreling on stage from behind me, screaming, "He's choking! He's choking!" Then he grabs me around the waist and jabs his fists into my belly. I've been Heimliched!

Those of you who know about the Heimlich maneuver will remember that basically it forces the air out of your lungs, blowing whatever is blocking your breathing out of your mouth. Those of you who have been staging this in your mind as you read will remember who is directly across from me. Those of you with even minimal powers of prediction will know what happens next. An unholy mix of partially chewed Hostess chocolate cupcakes spews out my mouth and spatters all

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over Tiffany. I am filled with deeper horror than any I have ever known.

Wrenching my way out of Mikey's grasp, I bolt around the table to clean her off. Unfortunately, the table is close to the edge of the stage. Too close. Tripping over my untied shoelace, I hurtle headfirst into the darkness. *(Beat)* Okay, I probably could have accepted the broken leg. I might even have been able to live with the memory of the look on Tiffany's face. But when Mikey told me that my fly had been open during the entire fiasco, that was too much! Anyway, that's how I ended up in this hospital bed, staring at my right leg, which is up in traction.

MIKEY: Tough luck, Murphy.

I try to remember that he is my friend and really thought he was saving my life when he Heimliched me. It is not easy.

MIKEY: Cheer up. It couldn't get worse than this.

(Makes a disgusted face) Right . . . . After all, my name is still Murphy Murphy. And I **am** thirteen years

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old. I don't even want to think about what might happen

next week.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Bruce Coville
Book: Oddest of All
ISBN: 978-0152058081
Publisher: Harcourt Children's Books
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2008

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

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